🌻 !050 Coding with Excel

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Summary

Most people will probably skip this page, but if you are interested in learning about the basic ideas of causal mapping without using our app at all, but just using a spreadsheet program, read on!

You will learn:

- How to do causal mapping with Excel
- How to upload causal mapping data from your own Excel file to Causal Map where you can analyse it and visualise the data. Or you can use other software like Gephi for visualisation.
- Remember that uploading and analysing data in Causal Map is completely free: you only need a subscription for using the Causal Map interface for coding your data.

Download our example Excel file

Now we are going to back to the basics of causal mapping. You don't need Causal Map App, or any other dedicated application, to do causal mapping. You can use Excel or any spreadsheet program.

Causal maps store information about links of causal influence between two or more factors alongside the evidence for each link. We call the chunks of text, for example from interview transcripts, which potentially contain claims about causal connections, "statements".

Here is an example Excel file, it contains example statements from our standard example file. You can use it to practice manual causal mapping.

There are several tabs, but the only ones you need to change are `links` and `codebook`.

The `links` tab already contains a couple of example links, otherwise known as an edge-list, the starting point for any causal map. The factors in the `from_label` column affect the factors in the `to_label` column. For example, the `from_label` column contains influence factors such as Improved/increased crops which influence the consequence factor in the next column, like Increased income. It is these links that could then displayed in a causal map.

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You will notice, in this example, that the columns in the links tab are dropdown lists when you click on the triangles in each cell. These dropdown lists are fed from the labels listed in the `codebook` tab. So you can change the options available by editing or adding labels in the factors tab. But you can also add new labels simply by typing in the cell.

Doing your own coding

So to actually do your causal mapping, you need to make sure that the `statement_id` and `statement_text` columns in every row in the `links` tab correspond to a `statement_id` and `text` from the `statements` tab. You might want to start out by copying all of the rows (but just the first two columns) from the `statements` tab into vacant rows in the `links` tab. Don't actually edit anything in the `statements` tab (or the `sources` or `questions` tabs).

1	statement_id	text	
2	MSY-3 | 1	This is a fully coded example file to showcase the	MSY-
3	MSY-3 | 2	There has been a lot of changes for the better, w	MSY-
4	MSY-3 | 3	Improved	MSY-
5	MSY-3 | 4	There has been improvements as we now do a lo	MSY-
6	MSY-3 | 5	Yes there have been some changes to how we pl	MSY-
7	MSY-3 | 6	Increased	MSY-
8	MSY-3 | 7	The main reason for this is the fact that we now p	MSY-
9	MSY-3 | 8	Yes there has been changes because my family ca	MSY-
10	MSY-3 | 9	Increased	MSY-

The first two columns of the `statements` tab.

Then,

- identify an actual causal claim within the `statement_text` column.
- Copy the piece of text which is evidence of the causal claim into the `quote` column.
- Type or select the `from_factor` and `to_factor` labels to show what causal factor did the influencing and what causal factor was influenced. If you want you can use hierarchical and opposites coding just like in the Causal Map app.

As you can create several links for one statement, the same `statement_id` and `statement_text` can be repeated several times, usually with different `quote`, `from_label` and `to_label`. It doesn't matter if you have rows in the `links` table which don't have any entries in the `quote`, `from_label` or `to_label` columns; they will be ignored when you upload your data to Causal Map.

If you want to create an extra link from an existing statement,

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one easy way is to simply copy the row, then right-click on the left-hand border of the Excel sheet around the row where you want to add a new row, and press “insert copied cells”. Remember to change the `quote`, `from_label` and `to_label` for your new link.

You can download the example file play around with it or use it as a template for your own map.

Uploading your file to Causal Map

TODO: add this

Visualising your data with other tools

Also once in excel format, your data becomes compatible with other data visualisation tools like Gephi. If you want to know more about that check out the video below on using the causal map app alongside other data visualisation tools.

Things to think about: drawbacks of using Excel

Causal mapping using Excel is pretty simple but of course it isn’t as convenient as in a dedicated app.

- You’ll notice that if you create a new label in the `from_label` column, it won’t be suggested as a label in the `to_label` column, and vice versa. After you’ve done a bit of coding, you’ll probably want to look through the labels you’ve created in these two columns, tidy them up a bit, and add any new labels to the `codebook` tab so that they will be provided as suggestions as you continue to code.

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